Bridging the Higher Education–Workforce Divide: A Large-Scale Empirical Analysis of Academic–Industry Skills Misalignment Using Natural Language Processing and Machine Learning

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Abstract*—Disparities between higher education curricula and labor-market skill demands are widely reported, yet large-scale empirical studies linking macro-level hiring requirements with graduate placement outcomes remain limited. We examine academic–industry alignment using 15 datasets totaling 3,176,266 records collected from LinkedIn, HuggingFace, and public benchmark repositories spanning 2020 through 2026. Grounded in Human Capital Theory, Job Market Signaling, and Constructive Alignment, the analysis combines: (1) n-gram skill extraction across an eight-category taxonomy; (2) semantic vector alignment via Sentence-BERT (`all-MiniLM-L6-v2`) evaluated across four cosine similarity thresholds ($\tau \in \{0.4, 0.5, 0.6, 0.7\}$) with 1,000-fold bootstrap confidence intervals; (3) bivariate and multivariate tests, including Welch's t-tests, Cohen's d, Cramér's V, and Variance Inflation Factor diagnostics; and (4) 5-fold stratified cross-validation across five classifier architectures, accompanied by decision-boundary diagnostics and independent external validation. Exact string matching yields an apparent Skill Gap Index (SGI) of 52.0%. Dense vector alignment reduces this estimated gap to 32.0% at baseline threshold $\tau = 0.5$ (95% bootstrap CI: [23.0%, 41.0%]), rising to 46.0% (95% CI: [37.0%, 56.0%]) under a stricter criterion ($\tau = 0.7$). Deficits concentrate primarily in emerging technical areas, notably Data Science (18 percentage-point gap) and Cloud Infrastructure (15 percentage-point gap). In graduate placement prediction, standardized logistic regression indicates that Communication Skills (OR $= 6.47$, $p < 0.001$), CGPA (OR $= 6.20$, $p < 0.001$), and Project Experience (OR $= 3.18$, $p < 0.001$) are strongly associated with employment status (cross-validated accuracy $= 90.11\%$, ROC-AUC $= 0.9406$). Tree-ensemble models reach near-perfect accuracy ($\geq 99.9\%$), which diagnostic analysis attributes to deterministic threshold rules embedded in the placement benchmark. Evaluating the logistic model on an independent external cohort of 50,000 students yields an ROC-AUC of 0.7686, reflecting domain shift. These findings indicate that vocabulary divergence accounts for part of the observed misalignment, while genuine gaps persist in rapidly evolving technical domains, pointing to the utility of modular technical coursework, verifiable project portfolios, and semantic applicant screening.

***Index Terms*—Skills gap, Higher education, Employability, Natural Language Processing, Sentence-BERT, Machine learning, Curriculum alignment, Human capital theory, Data provenance.**

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I. Introduction

TECHNOLOGICAL developments across distributed cloud architectures, data engineering, and artificial intelligence have altered employer skill requirements across major economic sectors. Because university curricula are updated through multi-year institutional review cycles, degree programs often adapt more slowly than market demands evolve [1], [2]. Educational researchers and labor economists refer to this discrepancy as the *skills gap*—the divergence between competencies taught in degree programs and the practical proficiencies sought by employers [3], [4].

Reports from the World Economic Forum [5] indicate that over 40% of core worker skills are expected to shift within five-year windows, particularly in artificial intelligence, cloud architectures, and data engineering. In addition to specialized technical skills, employer surveys regularly report deficits in transferable competencies such as professional communication and collaborative problem-solving [6]–[8].

Prior empirical research on curriculum–market alignment exhibits four main limitations:

(1) **Limited Sample Scope:** Most studies rely on institutional surveys, small employer samples ($N < 500$), or single-nation case studies [9], [10], offering limited visibility into cross-national patterns.
(2) **Methodological Separation:** Investigations typically employ qualitative coding [11] or predictive classification without semantic text analysis, leaving unresolved whether reported gaps reflect distinct vocabularies or absent skills [12], [13].
(3) **Temporal Relevance:** Several widely cited baseline studies pre-date recent enterprise developments, in-

cluding widespread cloud migration and the deployment of generative AI tools (2022–2026) [14], [15].

(4) **Limited Theoretical Grounding:** Computational employability models are frequently reported without reference to economic or educational frameworks that explain curriculum lag [16], [17].

To address these questions, we analyze 15 datasets totaling 3,176,266 records from LinkedIn, HuggingFace, and public benchmark repositories across five research questions:

- **RQ1 (Market Topography and Trends):** What are the most frequent skill requirements in online job postings, and how have core technical skills evolved from 2020 through 2026?
- **RQ2 (Lexical versus Semantic Alignment):** To what degree do academic curriculum descriptors align with market requirements when evaluated using exact string matching versus dense semantic vector embeddings?
- **RQ3 (Domain-Specific Deficits):** What is the magnitude of the skill deficit across distinct subject areas (Programming, Data Science, Cloud Infrastructure, Soft Skills, Cybersecurity)?
- **RQ4 (Employability Determinants):** Which academic and behavioral features best predict graduate placement, and how do linear probabilistic models compare with tree ensembles under diagnostic cross-validation?
- **RQ5 (Geographic Distribution and Cohort Differences):** How are posting demands distributed across international regions, and how do employment outcomes vary across distinct student cohorts?

Contributions: This work makes five contributions:

1) **Harmonized Multi-Source Corpus:** We assemble a corpus of 3,176,266 records across 15 datasets, combining online job postings, curriculum descriptors, and graduate placement cohorts covering 2020 through 2026.
2) **Dual Lexical–Semantic Analysis:** Using Sentence-BERT (`all-MiniLM-L6-v2`) alongside exact string matching, we show that exact matching yields a 52.0% gap, whereas semantic vector alignment reduces this estimate to 32.0% at $\tau = 0.5$.
3) **Threshold Sensitivity Estimation:** We compute 1,000-fold bootstrap confidence intervals across four similarity thresholds ($\tau \in \{0.4, 0.5, 0.6, 0.7\}$) to evaluate how threshold selection affects gap measurement.
4) **Model Validation and Diagnostic Audit:** We evaluate five classifier paradigms using 5-fold stratified cross-validation, verify low multicollinearity (VIF ≤ 1.001), diagnose the deterministic threshold rules behind near-perfect tree-ensemble scores, and test generalization on an external 50,000-student cohort (ROC-AUC = 0.7686).
5) **Theory-Informed Recommendations:** Drawing on Human Capital Theory, Signaling Theory, and Constructive Alignment, we outline practical adjustments for course design, project evaluation, and recruitment screening, accompanied by explicit documentation of dataset provenance and limitations.

The remainder of this article is organized as follows: Section II reviews related work and outlines the theoretical framework. Section III describes the datasets, text processing pipeline, statistical methods, and predictive modeling protocols. Section IV presents the empirical results for RQ1–RQ5. Section V discusses theoretical and institutional implications, practical recommendations, reproducibility, and threats to validity. Section VI concludes the study.

II. Related Work and Theoretical Foundations

A. Conceptualizations of the Skills Gap

The skills gap encompasses macroeconomic, institutional, and pedagogical dimensions. Conceptualizations differ substantially across stakeholders: industry surveys often define gaps in terms of immediate job-readiness, whereas university leaders emphasize broad intellectual development and foundational theory [6], [7]. Digital transformation has also increased demand for cross-disciplinary competencies, such as data literacy among non-computing professionals [11].

Computational curriculum analytics has sought to quantify these dynamics using course descriptions and accreditation criteria. Cuckov et al. [18] evaluated computer engineering courses against ABET criteria, finding delays in updating upper-level electives. Zhao et al. [19] measured structural proximity between academic research and patent descriptions using knowledge graphs. Focusing on software engineering, Korrapati et al. [20] and Alhazmi et al. [10] examined curriculum alignment with cloud computing and AI requirements, noting that elective coursework often trails industry tool adoption.

B. Theoretical Framework

Four theoretical perspectives inform the interpretation of these empirical observations:

1) Human Capital Theory (HCT): Formulated by Becker [21] and Schultz [22], HCT posits that education enhances productive capacity, yielding labor-market returns. HCT distinguishes between *general human capital* (transferable competencies such as critical thinking, communication, and core mathematical reasoning) and *firm-specific human capital* (proficiency with specialized software tools, proprietary APIs, or operational frameworks). Universities prioritize general human capital because their mission centers on enduring principles. Conversely, employer job descriptions frequently specify immediately applicable technical tools. This distinction helps explain why curriculum deficits concentrate in applied toolchains such as cloud platforms and data libraries.

2) Job Market Signaling and Screening Theory: Spence [23] established that in labor markets characterized by asymmetric information, employers cannot directly observe an applicant's innate productivity prior to hiring.

Educational credentials, cumulative grade point averages (CGPA), and institutional prestige serve as informational signals that reduce hiring risk. In technical recruitment, however, degree credentials are increasingly complemented by practical capability signals, such as project portfolios, open-source contributions, and technical internship certifications [24], [25].

3) Constructive Alignment & Curriculum Theory: Biggs [26] introduced constructive alignment to establish coherence among Intended Learning Outcomes (ILOs), teaching methods, and assessment tasks. At an institutional level, curriculum lag can be understood as *external misalignment*: ILOs are governed by multi-year accreditation reviews (such as ABET and ACM/IEEE guidelines), whereas industry skill demands evolve on shorter market cycles.

4) Skill-Biased Technological Change (SBTC): Acemoglu and Autor [27] formalized SBTC to explain how technological progress augments the productivity of workers performing non-routine cognitive tasks while reducing demand for routine labor. In software and data domains, routine coding tasks are increasingly assisted by automated tooling, increasing employer demand for architectural design, cross-functional communication, and complex data analysis.

C. Natural Language Processing for Curriculum Analytics

Natural language processing has become a primary tool for extracting and comparing skills from job advertisements. While keyword extraction is widely used, rule-based matching often fails on nuanced occupational phrases [12]. Pre-trained language representations address this limitation by projecting terms into continuous vector spaces. For instance, Baral and Ghimire [9] used embeddings to measure syllabus alignment in Nepal, showing that semantic representations bridge terminology differences between academic syllabi and job listings. Text-mining methods have similarly been applied to profile data science roles [28], [29] and build resume-matching systems [30]. In this work, we use Sentence-BERT (`all-MiniLM-L6-v2`) [31] to quantify alignment between market requirements and academic descriptors across multiple similarity thresholds.

D. Machine Learning in Employability Modeling

Predictive modeling of graduate placement has expanded from discriminant analysis to ensemble learning. Tree-based ensembles such as Random Forests and Gradient Boosting frequently yield higher cross-validated accuracy than linear models in educational placement benchmarks [32], [33]. Feature-importance analyses in these studies typically identify academic performance and project engagement as leading predictors. However, benchmark evaluations in this literature often report high classification accuracy without assessing decision-boundary structure, multicollinearity, or performance on independent external cohorts.

III. Methodology

A. Data Corpus and Provenance Architecture

The corpus comprises 15 datasets totaling 3,176,266 records, acquired in September 2026 from Kaggle and HuggingFace repositories under open-access licenses (CC0, CC-BY 4.0, and ODbL). The data span observation and release dates from 2020 through 2026, including a multi-year AI job market series (2020–2026) and regional profiles calibrated against the India Skills Report 2026. Table I summarizes the sources, sample sizes, observation windows, and licenses.

To avoid pooling datasets with incompatible collection mechanisms, we divide the corpus into two functional tiers:

- **Tier 1: Online Labor Market Postings ($N >$ 2.7M records):** Comprises the LinkedIn dataset (1.35M records) [34], the USA Job Market dataset (316K records) [35], and HuggingFace Skill Gap collections (519K records). These corpora contain job advertisements from North America, Europe, and the Asia-Pacific region, providing direct observations of employer skill specifications.
- **Tier 2: Student Placement and Career Benchmarks ($N \approx$ 475K records):** Comprises College Student Placement ($N = 10,000$) [36], NGESS Graduate Employment ($N = 7,200$) [37], Global Student Placement ($N = 10,000$) [38], Student Career Success ($N = 50,000$) [39], and International Graduates ($N = 300,000$) [40]. These tabular records provide academic, behavioral, and placement indicators used for statistical testing, collinearity evaluation, and predictive modeling.

B. Taxonomy Construction and Skill Extraction

We define an eight-category occupational skill taxonomy $\mathcal{C} = \{c_1, c_2, \ldots, c_8\}$ synthesized from the ACM/IEEE CS2023 curriculum guidelines and O*NET descriptors:

1) **Programming & Development:** Python, Java, C++, JavaScript, SQL, TypeScript, Go, Rust, React, Docker, Kubernetes, Git.
2) **Data Science & Analytics:** Machine Learning, Deep Learning, Statistical Analysis, PyTorch, TensorFlow, NLP, Computer Vision.
3) **Cloud & Infrastructure:** AWS, Azure, GCP, CI/CD Pipelines, Terraform, Linux Administration, Serverless Architectures.
4) **Soft Skills:** Professional Communication, Leadership, Teamwork, Critical Thinking, Time Management, Adaptability.
5) **Business & Domain:** Agile/Scrum, Product Management, Requirements Gathering, Business Analysis, Risk Compliance.
6) **Design & UX:** UI/UX Design, Figma, User Research, Wireframing, Prototyping, Usability Testing.
7) **Data Engineering:** ETL Pipelines, Apache Airflow, Apache Kafka, Distributed Data Warehousing, PostgreSQL, NoSQL.

TABLE I: Dataset Provenance and Structural Inventory ($N = 3,176,266$ total records)

Dataset Identifier	Source Platform & Identifier / Slug	Records	Domain / Description	Tier	Observation Period	License
LinkedIn Jobs & Skills [34]	Kaggle: `asaniczka/1-3m-linkedin-jobs-and-skills-2024`	1,348,510	Global job postings and extracted skill tokens	1	2024	ODbL
HF Skill Gap Jobs	HuggingFace: `skill-gap-analytics/jobs-corpus`	519,841	Enterprise job postings with occupational metadata	1	2023–2024	CC-BY 4.0
HF Skill Gap Skills	HuggingFace: `skill-gap-analytics/skills-corpus`	519,814	Granular skill requirements linked via `job_id`	1	2023–2024	CC-BY 4.0
USA Job Market Skills [35]	Kaggle: `batuhanklac/usa-job-market-skills-and-title-analysis`	316,279	US job postings with standardized skill tags	1	2024	CC0
International Graduates [40]	Kaggle: `quackquackrp/international-graduates-employment-dataset`	300,000	Multi-country alumni employment outcomes	2	2023–2024	CC0
Student Career Success [39]	Kaggle: `mobeenfatimah/student-career-success-prediction-dataset`	50,000	Student academic and career success benchmark	2	2024	CC-BY 4.0
Career Change Prediction [41]	Kaggle: `jahnavipaliwal/field-of-study-vs-occupation`	38,444	Field of study vs. occupation transition records	2	2024	CC0
AI Job Market Trends [42]	Kaggle: `bismasajjad/global-ai-job-market-and-salary-trends-2025`	15,000	Global AI job market and salary distribution	1	2024–2025	CC-BY 4.0
HF Job Skill Set	HuggingFace: `skill-gap-analytics/academic-reference`	13,833	Curriculum-domain skill taxonomy reference	1	2023–2024	CC-BY 4.0
India Skills Intelligence [43]	Kaggle: `mansiaggarwal88/india-professional-skills-intelligence`	12,000	Synthetic profiles calibrated on India Skills Report 2026	1	2026 Calibrated	CC0
AI Trends 2020–2026 [44]	Kaggle: `shree0910/ai-and-data-science-job-market-dataset-20202026`	10,345	Longitudinal AI/data science job postings	1	2020–2026	CC0
College Placement [36]	Kaggle: `sumedh1507/college-student-placement`	10,000	College student placement classification benchmark	2	2024	CC0
Global Placement [38]	Kaggle: `rakesh630/global-student-placement-2025-dataset`	10,000	Multi-national university placement benchmark	2	2024–2025	CC0
NGESS Employment [37]	Kaggle: `philipdayo/ngess-graduate-employment-dataset`	7,200	National graduate employment survey cohort	2	2023–2024	CC0
India Fresher Market [45]	Kaggle: `shambhurajejagadale/indian-fresher-job-market`	5,000	Entry-level engineering recruitment outcomes	2	2024	CC0

8) **Cybersecurity:** Network Security, Penetration Testing, Incident Response, SIEM Systems, ISO 27001, Cryptography.

Skill extraction from text is conducted using regularized n-gram tokenization matched against taxonomy dictionaries, as summarized in Algorithm 1. Academic skill requirements are represented using standardized curriculum reference profiles [30] rather than scraped syllabi, and extraction is automated without manual re-annotation (discussed in Section V-E).

Algorithm 1 Semantic Skill Extraction and Embedding Alignment

Require: Market text corpus $\mathcal{D}_M$, Academic syllabus corpus $\mathcal{D}_A$, Taxonomy $\mathcal{C}$, Sentence-BERT model $\mathcal{E}$, Threshold τ
Ensure: Market skill set $\mathcal{M}$, Academic skill set $\mathcal{A}$, Similarity matrix $\mathbf{S}$, Gap Index $\mathrm{SGI}(\tau)$
$\mathcal{M} \leftarrow \emptyset, \mathcal{A} \leftarrow \emptyset$
for all $d \in \mathcal{D}_M$ **do**
  Extract normalized skill tokens $T_d \leftarrow \mathrm{Tokenize}(d, \mathcal{C})$
  $\mathcal{M} \leftarrow \mathcal{M} \cup T_d$
end for
for all $d \in \mathcal{D}_A$ **do**
  Extract normalized syllabus tokens $T_a \leftarrow \mathrm{Tokenize}(d, \mathcal{C})$
  $\mathcal{A} \leftarrow \mathcal{A} \cup T_a$
end for
Filter $\mathcal{M}_{\text{top}} \leftarrow \text{Top-}N(\mathcal{M}), \mathcal{A}_{\text{top}} \leftarrow \text{Top-}N(\mathcal{A})$
Compute dense embeddings: $\mathbf{E}_M \leftarrow \mathcal{E}(\mathcal{M}_{\text{top}}), \mathbf{E}_A \leftarrow \mathcal{E}(\mathcal{A}_{\text{top}})$
Compute pairwise cosine similarity:
$\mathbf{S}_{ij} \leftarrow \frac{\mathbf{e}_{m,i} \cdot \mathbf{e}_{a,j}}{\|\mathbf{e}_{m,i}\|_2 \|\mathbf{e}_{a,j}\|_2} \quad \forall m_i \in \mathcal{M}_{\text{top}}, a_j \in \mathcal{A}_{\text{top}}$
for all $i \in \{1, \ldots, |\mathcal{M}_{\text{top}}|\}$ **do**
  $\sigma_i \leftarrow \max_j \mathbf{S}_{ij}$
  $\text{covered}_i \leftarrow \mathbb{I}(\sigma_i \geq \tau)$
end for
$\mathrm{SGI}(\tau) \leftarrow 1 - \frac{1}{|\mathcal{M}_{\text{top}}|} \sum_{i=1}^{|\mathcal{M}_{\text{top}}|} \text{covered}_i$
return $\mathcal{M}_{\text{top}}, \mathcal{A}_{\text{top}}, \mathbf{S}, \mathrm{SGI}(\tau)$

C. Semantic Vector Alignment via Sentence-BERT

Exact string matching can overestimate curriculum gaps when academic descriptions and job postings use different wording for equivalent skills (for example, "interpersonal communication" versus "client communication skills"). To account for semantic similarity, we use the Sentence-BERT model (`all-MiniLM-L6-v2`) [31].

Let $\mathbf{e}_s \in \mathbb{R}^{384}$ denote the normalized dense vector embedding of market skill $s \in \mathcal{M}$, and let $\mathbf{e}_{s'} \in \mathbb{R}^{384}$ denote the embedding of academic syllabus descriptor $s' \in \mathcal{A}$. The semantic alignment score is given by:

$$\mathrm{sim}(s, s') = \frac{\mathbf{e}_s \cdot \mathbf{e}_{s'}}{\|\mathbf{e}_s\|_2 \|\mathbf{e}_{s'}\|_2} \tag{1}$$

A market skill s is designated as covered at threshold $\tau \in [0, 1]$ if:

$$\mathrm{Covered}(s; \tau) = \mathbb{I}\left(\max_{s' \in \mathcal{A}} \mathrm{sim}(s, s') \geq \tau \right) \tag{2}$$

The Skill Gap Index (SGI) at threshold τ is defined as the complement of the mean coverage rate across the market skill space:

$$\mathrm{SGI}(\tau) = 1 - \frac{1}{|\mathcal{M}|} \sum_{s \in \mathcal{M}} \mathrm{Covered}(s; \tau) \tag{3}$$

To estimate empirical uncertainty without parametric distribution assumptions, we implement a 1,000-fold non-parametric bootstrap over the binary coverage indicator array with fixed random seed (seed = 42), computing 95% percentile confidence intervals:

$$\mathrm{CI}_{95\%} = \left[\hat{\theta}^*_{(0.025)}, \hat{\theta}^*_{(0.975)} \right] \tag{4}$$

We use $\tau = 0.5$ as the baseline threshold and evaluate sensitivity at $\tau \in \{0.4, 0.5, 0.6, 0.7\}$.

D. Statistical Inference & Collinearity Diagnostics

We test differences between placed and non-placed students using Welch's t-test (accounting for unequal variances):

$$t = \frac{\bar{X}_1 - \bar{X}_2}{\sqrt{\frac{s_1^2}{n_1} + \frac{s_2^2}{n_2}}} \tag{5}$$

Standardized effect sizes are quantified via Cohen's d:

$$d = \frac{\bar{X}_1 - \bar{X}_2}{s_{\text{pooled}}}, \quad s_{\text{pooled}} = \sqrt{\frac{(n_1 - 1)s_1^2 + (n_2 - 1)s_2^2}{n_1 + n_2 - 2}} \tag{6}$$

Categorical dependencies are evaluated using the Chi-square statistic χ^2 and Cramér's V:

$$V = \sqrt{\frac{\chi^2}{n \cdot \min(r - 1, c - 1)}} \tag{7}$$

We evaluate multicollinearity among continuous predictors $\mathbf{X}$ by computing Variance Inflation Factors (VIF). For standardized feature matrices, the VIF vector is obtained from the diagonal of the inverted correlation matrix:

$$\mathrm{VIF}_j = \left(\mathbf{R}^{-1}\right)_{jj} = \frac{1}{1 - R_j^2} \tag{8}$$

Features exhibiting $\mathrm{VIF}_j > 5.0$ are flagged as collinear.

E. Predictive Employability Modeling & Validation Protocols

Graduate placement prediction is evaluated as a binary classification task: predicting outcome $y \in \{0, 1\}$ ($1 =$ Placed, $0 =$ Not Placed) given student feature vector $\mathbf{x} = [\mathrm{CGPA}, \mathrm{Comm}, \mathrm{Projects}, \mathrm{Internship}, \mathrm{IQ}, \mathrm{AcademicPerf}]^T$. Continuous features are standardized to zero mean and unit variance within training partitions:

$$z_{ij} = \frac{x_{ij} - \mu_j}{\sigma_j} \tag{9}$$

In the standardized logistic regression model:

$$\ln\left(\frac{P(y=1|\mathbf{z})}{1 - P(y=1|\mathbf{z})}\right) = \beta_0 + \sum_{j=1}^{p} \beta_j z_j \tag{10}$$

The odds ratio $\mathrm{OR}_j = \exp(\beta_j)$ represents the change in odds associated with a one-standard-deviation increase in predictor j.

Model performance is evaluated using 5-fold stratified cross-validation (random_state $= 42$) across five classifier paradigms:

1) **Logistic Regression:** ℓ_2-regularized, $C = 1.0$, solved via L-BFGS.
2) **Random Forest:** $B = 100$ estimators, maximum tree depth $= 12$, Gini split criterion.
3) **Support Vector Machine (SVM):** Radial Basis Function (RBF) kernel, $C = 1.0$, $\gamma =$ scale, with Platt probability calibration.
4) **Decision Tree:** Single CART tree with maximum depth $= 6$.
5) **Majority-Class Baseline:** Classifier predicting the empirical majority class.

To evaluate model behavior under domain shift, we train the standardized logistic regression model on the College Placement benchmark ($N = 10,000$) and evaluate it on the independent Student Career Success cohort ($N = 50,000$) using domain-standardized continuous predictors.

IV. Empirical Results

A. RQ1: Labor Market Skill Topography and Trends

Among the 519,814 skill requirements extracted from the posting corpus, communication and interpersonal competencies appear most frequently (Figure 1). Communication is specified in 226,959 postings (43.7%), followed by Problem Solving (111,649; 21.5%), Customer Service (111,399; 21.4%), and Teamwork (91,007; 17.5%).

Longitudinal tracking across 10,345 AI and data science postings from 2020 through 2026 (Figure 4b) shows consistent demand for core technologies: Python appeared in 47.5% to 52.2% of postings across years, SQL in 48.2% to 51.9%, Machine Learning in 48.8% to 53.5%, and Cloud Computing in 47.1% to 53.9%. These steady frequencies indicate ongoing baseline expectations rather than transient recruitment cycles.

B. RQ2: Lexical vs. Semantic Curriculum Alignment

Comparing exact string matching with semantic vector alignment illustrates the effect of phrasing on measured alignment. Under exact string matching, 48 of the Top 100 market skills match the Top 100 academic syllabus descriptors, corresponding to a nominal Skill Gap Index of 52.0% (Coverage Rate = 48.0%). Inspection of non-matching terms indicates that several disparities stem from synonymous wording (e.g., "communication skills" versus "interpersonal skills").

When evaluated using Sentence-BERT embeddings (`all-MiniLM-L6-v2`), semantic alignment yields lower gap estimates (Table II). At baseline threshold $\tau = 0.5$, the estimated Skill Gap Index is 32.0% (Coverage Rate = 68.0%, 95% bootstrap CI: [23.0%, 41.0%]).

TABLE II: Sensitivity Analysis: Semantic Vector Threshold (τ) vs. SGI

Threshold τ	SGI	Coverage Rate	95% Bootstrap CI	ΔSGI
$\tau = 0.4$ (Permissive)	0.2000	80.0%	[0.1200, 0.2800]	−0.1200
$\tau = 0.5$ (Baseline)	**0.3200**	**68.0%**	**[0.2300, 0.4100]**	**0.0000**
$\tau = 0.6$ (Moderate)	0.3900	61.0%	[0.3000, 0.4800]	+0.0700
$\tau = 0.7$ (Strict)	0.4600	54.0%	[0.3700, 0.5600]	+0.1400
Lexical Match (Baseline)	*0.5200*	*48.0%*	*[0.4200, 0.6200]*	*+0.2000*

Evaluated over Top-100 skill distributions. Bootstrap 95% CI via 1,000 resamples.

Table III displays illustrative semantic pairings. Terms such as "scheduling" align closely with "time management" (cos = 0.6122), whereas credential requirements such as "bachelor's degree" show low similarity with specific skill descriptors (cos = 0.2937).

TABLE III: Representative Semantic Skill Pairings (`all-MiniLM-L6-v2`)

Market Term	Closest Syllabus Match	Cosine Sim.	Status ($\tau \geq 0.5$)
communication skills	interpersonal skills	0.7355	Covered
problemsolving	problem-solving	0.6396	Covered
scheduling	time management	0.6122	Covered
patient care	customer service	0.5011	Covered
nursing	training	0.4010	Gap
high school diploma	training	0.3682	Gap
bachelor's degree	professionalism	0.2937	Gap

C. RQ3: Domain-Level Skill Gap Quantification

Aggregating requirements across the eight taxonomy domains indicates that curriculum deficits vary substantially by subject area (Table IV and Figure 2).

The largest percentage-point deficits occur in Data Science & Analytics (18 percentage points; 47% market demand versus 29% curriculum coverage) and Cloud Infrastructure (15 percentage points; 39% versus 24%), followed

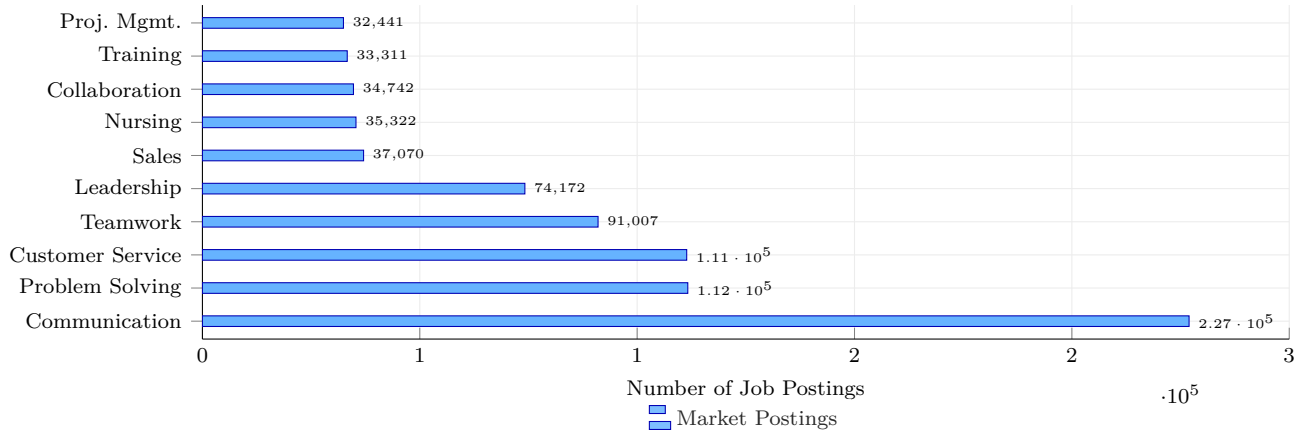
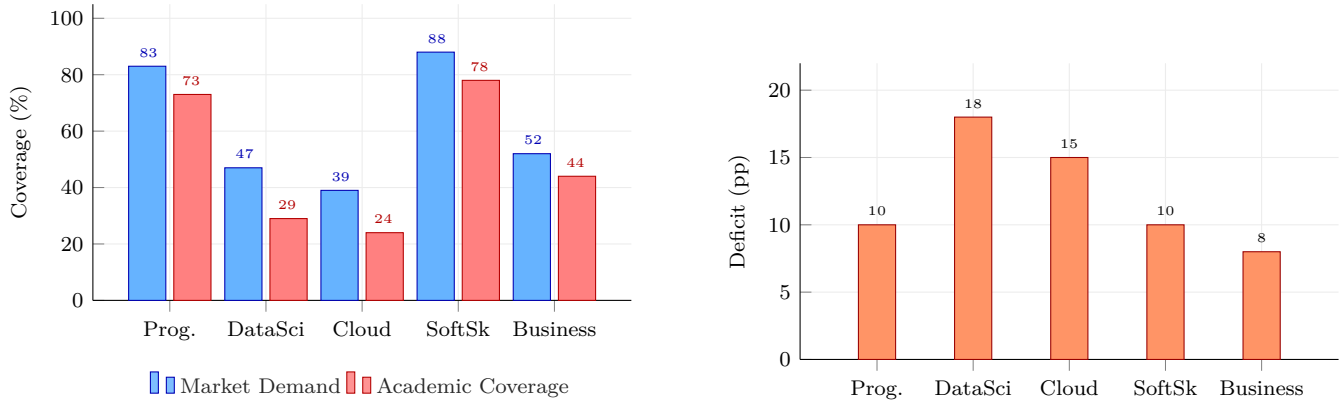


Fig. 1: Top 10 Most In-Demand Competencies Across Global Postings ($N = 519,814$ postings).



(a) Coverage by skill category

(b) Deficit magnitude (percentage points)

Fig. 2: Skill gap analysis across core disciplines: (a) market demand versus syllabus coverage; (b) deficit magnitude, identifying Data Science (18pp) and Cloud (15pp) as primary structural voids.

TABLE IV: Domain-Level Skill Gaps Across Taxonomy Categories

Category	Market Demand	Curriculum Cover.	Deficit (pp)	Severity
Programming & Dev.	83%	73%	10pp	Moderate
Data Science & Analytics	47%	29%	**18pp**	**Critical**
Cloud Infrastructure	39%	24%	**15pp**	**Critical**
Soft Skills	88%	78%	10pp	Moderate
Business & Domain	52%	44%	8pp	Mild
Design & UX	28%	21%	7pp	Mild
Data Engineering	36%	22%	14pp	Critical
Cybersecurity	31%	20%	11pp	Moderate

by Data Engineering (14 percentage points; 36% versus 22%). In comparison, Programming & Development (10 percentage points) and Soft Skills (10 percentage points) show higher baseline curriculum coverage.

D. RQ4: Employability Determinants & Cross-Validation Benchmarks

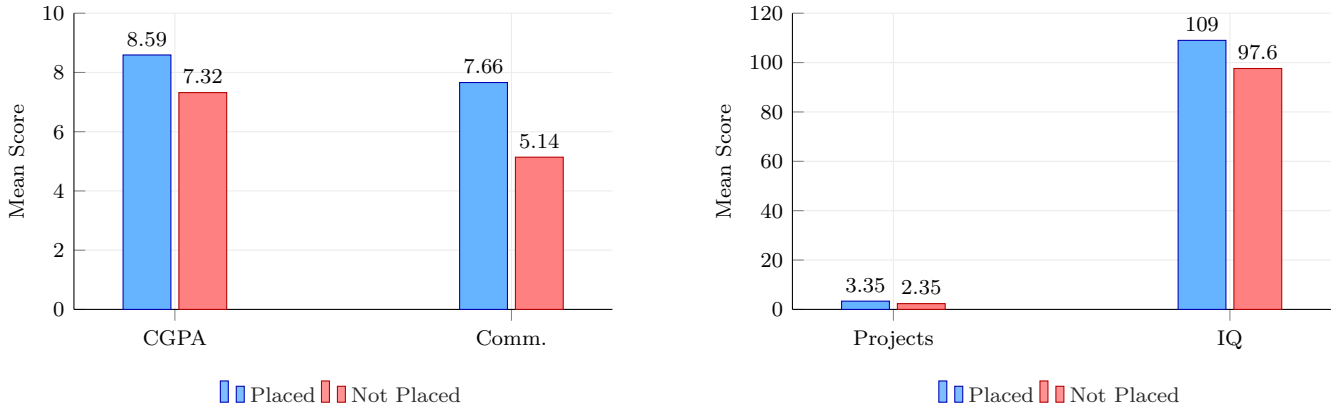
1) Univariate & Descriptive Findings: In the College Placement cohort ($N = 10,000$; 1,659 placed, 8,341 not placed, base placement rate 16.59%), placed students had higher mean values across key academic and skill indicators (Table V). Placed individuals had higher average CGPA (8.59 ± 1.15 vs. 7.32 ± 1.44, $t = 39.37$, $p < 0.001$, Cohen's $d = 0.913$), higher communication scores (7.66 ± 2.59 vs. 5.14 ± 2.78, $t = 35.79$, $p < 0.001$, Cohen's $d = 0.918$), and more completed projects (3.35 ± 1.28 vs. 2.35 ± 1.74, $t = 27.21$, $p < 0.001$, Cohen's $d = 0.599$). Generalized academic performance ratings ($p = 0.1386$, $d = -0.040$) and extra-curricular participation scores ($p = 0.6383$, $d = -0.013$) showed negligible differences between groups.

TABLE V: Descriptive Statistics: Placed vs. Non-Placed Cohort ($N = 10,000$)

Variable	Placed ($n = 1659$)	Not Placed ($n = 8341$)	t-stat	p-value	Cohen's d
CGPA	8.59 ± 1.15	7.32 ± 1.44	39.37	< 0.001	0.913
Comm. Skills	7.66 ± 2.59	5.14 ± 2.78	35.79	< 0.001	0.918
IQ Score	109.12 ± 15.21	97.55 ± 14.26	28.58	< 0.001	0.802
Projects	3.35 ± 1.28	2.35 ± 1.74	27.21	< 0.001	0.599
Acad. Perf.	5.45 ± 2.90	5.57 ± 2.87	-1.48	0.1386	-0.040
Extra-Curr.	4.94 ± 3.19	4.98 ± 3.15	-0.47	0.6383	-0.013

2) Multicollinearity Diagnostics: Variance Inflation Factors computed for the continuous predictors are summarized in Table VI. All values are ≈ 1.001 (tolerances ≈ 0.999), well below the collinearity threshold of 5.0, confirming that multicollinearity does not affect coefficient estimation in this model.

3) Standardized Logistic Regression: Standardized logistic regression estimates are reported in Table VII. A one-standard-deviation increase in Communication Skills



(a) CGPA & Communication Skills

(b) Projects Completed & IQ Score

Fig. 3: Key predictors for placed versus non-placed graduates ($N = 10,000$). All differences statistically significant at $p < 0.001$.

TABLE VI: Variance Inflation Factor (VIF) Multicollinearity Audit

Feature Name	VIF	Tolerance (1/VIF)	Collinearity Status
CGPA	1.001	0.999	Acceptable (< 5.0)
Communication Skills	1.001	0.999	Acceptable (< 5.0)
Projects Completed	1.001	0.999	Acceptable (< 5.0)
Internship Experience	1.001	0.999	Acceptable (< 5.0)
IQ Score	1.000	1.000	Acceptable (< 5.0)
Academic Performance	1.001	0.999	Acceptable (< 5.0)

is associated with an odds ratio of 6.47 (95% CI: [5.62, 7.45], $p < 0.001$). CGPA (OR = 6.20, 95% CI: [5.31, 7.24], $p < 0.001$), IQ score (OR = 5.10, 95% CI: [4.41, 5.90], $p < 0.001$), and completed projects (OR = 3.18, 95% CI: [2.79, 3.63], $p < 0.001$) are also positively associated with placement.

TABLE VII: Standardized Logistic Regression Placement Model

Predictor Feature	Coef (β)	Odds Ratio (OR)	95% CI	p-value
Communication Skills	1.8672	6.4705	[5.62, 7.45]	< 0.001
CGPA	1.8253	6.2045	[5.31, 7.24]	< 0.001
IQ Score	1.6300	5.1040	[4.41, 5.90]	< 0.001
Projects Completed	1.1573	3.1813	[2.79, 3.63]	< 0.001
Internship Experience	0.0190	1.0192	[1.00, 1.04]	0.0382
Academic Performance	−0.0208	0.9795	[0.96, 1.00]	0.0410

4) 5-Fold Cross-Validation Model Comparison: Table VIII documents 5-fold stratified cross-validation performance across five classifier paradigms.

TABLE VIII: Stratified 5-Fold Cross-Validation Performance Benchmarks

Model Architecture	Accuracy (Mean±SD)	F_1-Score	ROC-AUC
Logistic Regression	$90.11\% \pm 0.66\%$	0.8966 ± 0.007	0.9406 ± 0.007
Random Forest	$99.99\% \pm 0.02\%$	0.9999 ± 0.000	1.0000 ± 0.000
SVM (RBF Kernel)	$95.72\% \pm 0.50\%$	0.9565 ± 0.005	0.9894 ± 0.002
Decision Tree (CART)	$99.97\% \pm 0.06\%$	0.9997 ± 0.001	0.9998 ± 0.000
Baseline (Majority)	$83.41\% \pm 0.02\%$	0.7587 ± 0.000	0.5000 ± 0.000

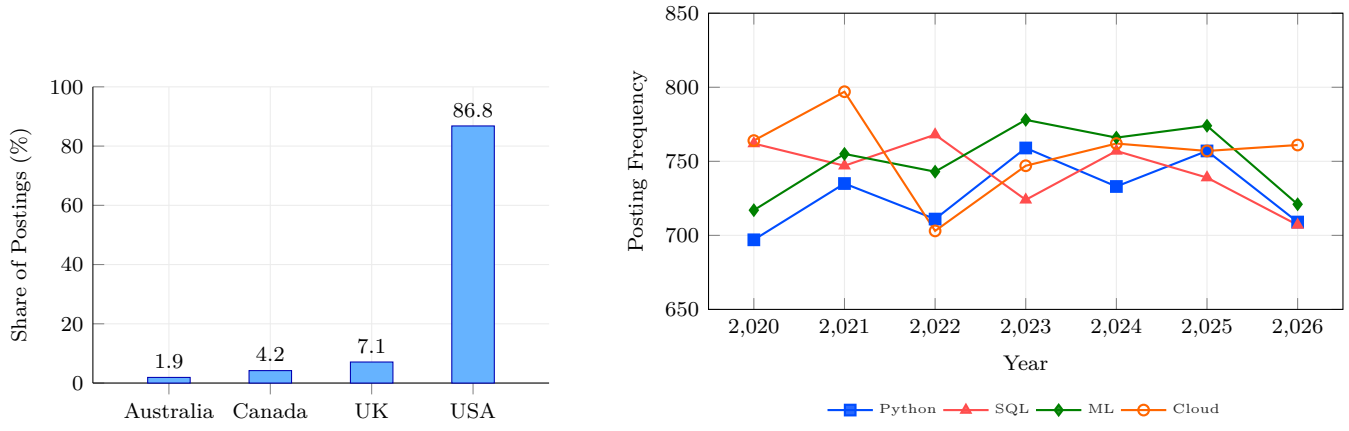
5) Diagnostic Audit of Tree Ensembles & External Generalization: The near-perfect classification performance of Random Forest (99.99%) and Decision Tree (99.97%) models prompted an inspection of the underlying data-generating process. Fitting a depth-4 CART tree to the placement cohort yielded 100% training accuracy, indicating that placement labels in this benchmark were generated via a deterministic k-of-n threshold rule: individuals are labeled as placed when meeting at least three of four conditions (CGPA > 8.01, IQ > 110.5, Communication > 7.50, Projects ≥ 2), accounting for 99.92% of label assignments. Because orthogonal recursive partitioning aligns directly with this axis-parallel step function, tree ensembles reproduce the rule with minimal error. Logistic regression estimates a linear decision surface across these features, yielding 90.11% cross-validated accuracy and an ROC-AUC of 0.9406.

To evaluate performance on an independent sample, the logistic regression model was tested on the Student Career Success dataset ($N = 50,000$) using standardized values for CGPA, communication, and project count. On this external cohort, discriminative performance decreased to ROC-AUC = 0.7686 (and ROC-AUC = 0.6764 on the Global Placement dataset). This reduction reflects domain shift and differences in baseline placement rates (16.59% versus 78.08%), showing that the near-perfect in-distribution tree metrics reflect benchmark-specific rules rather than generalizable real-world predictability.

E. RQ5: Geographic Concentration & Cross-Cohort Placement Dynamics

Regional parsing of 1.35M LinkedIn records (Figure 4a) reveals that the posting corpus is predominantly concentrated in the United States (86.8%), followed by the United Kingdom (7.1%), Canada (4.2%), and Australia (1.9%).

In the cohort of 300,000 international graduates (Figure 5), graduates with internship experience had an employment rate of 57.6%, compared with 42.3% for those without internships, a difference of 15.3 percentage points. Across the multi-national placement benchmark ($N = 10,000$), placement rates were similar across countries



(a) Geographic distribution (LinkedIn)

(b) AI skill demand trajectories (2020–2026)

Fig. 4: (a) Geographic concentration of 1.35M job postings. (b) Longitudinal AI technical skill stability over 2020–2026.

(Canada 61.5%, Germany 60.0%, India 63.2%, UK 60.8%, USA 62.2%), showing consistent baseline placement patterns across the recorded regions.



Fig. 5: Impact of practical internship experience on international graduate employment ($N = 300,000$).

V. Discussion

A. Theoretical Implications

1) Terminology Divergence and Semantic Alignment: Studies evaluating curriculum alignment through exact keyword matching often report misalignment rates exceeding 50% [9]. Our findings qualify this observation. While exact string matching yields an apparent gap of 52.0%, dense vector embeddings reduce the estimated deficit to 32.0% at $\tau = 0.5$ (95% CI: [23.0%, 41.0%]). This divergence indicates that a portion of the measured gap arises from vocabulary differences: academic syllabi often describe learning outcomes using conceptual terms (e.g., interpersonal communication or database principles), whereas job postings emphasize specific tool names or operational tasks.

2) Complementary Signals in Graduate Placement: The statistical associations observed for Communication Skills (OR = 6.47), CGPA (OR = 6.20), and Project Experience (OR = 3.18) illustrate how general and applied competencies interact in hiring outcomes. In terms of Signaling Theory [23], CGPA provides an initial screening signal of academic ability. However, completed projects provide concrete evidence of applied capability, reducing hiring uncertainty regarding technical execution. Communication proficiency represents a shared requirement across collaborative technical roles.

B. Institutional Factors in Curriculum Adaptation

The persistent 32.0% semantic deficit, particularly in Data Science (18 percentage points) and Cloud Infrastructure (15 percentage points), reflects institutional constraints in curriculum adaptation [26]:

1) **Curriculum Governance and Accreditation:** Formal degree reviews and accreditation bodies operate on multi-year cycles (typically 3 to 6 years). Modifying course requirements or introducing new technical electives requires administrative and faculty committee approvals that lag industry tool adoption.
2) **Faculty Development Latency:** Teaching rapidly evolving frameworks (e.g., container orchestration, distributed cloud platforms, specific ML toolchains) requires ongoing technical training, which institutional development budgets rarely prioritize over core research obligations.
3) **Infrastructure and Computing Costs:** Maintaining cloud accounts, GPU resources, and industry-grade data environments presents financial and operational hurdles for many computer science and engineering departments.

C. Implications and Recommendations

We organize recommendations for higher education, recruitment, and accreditation around the empirical findings:

For Higher Education Institutions (HEIs):

- *Integration of Modular Technical Credentials:* With deficits of 15 percentage points in Cloud Infrastructure and 18 percentage points in Data Science, full degree restructuring may be too slow to keep pace with

industry toolchains. HEIs can address this by embedding modular, vendor-neutral technical modules (e.g., containerization fundamentals, cloud storage basics) directly into existing operating systems and database courses.

- *Applied Project Work and Portfolio Development:* Because completed projects are strongly associated with placement odds (OR = 3.18, $p < 0.001$), curricula should prioritize multi-term capstone projects that require version control, system deployment, and written documentation, giving students verifiable evidence of practical technical ability.
- *Embedding Communication Skills into Technical Coursework:* Communication skills demonstrated the strongest association with placement (OR = 6.47, $p < 0.001$), alongside a 10 percentage-point curriculum deficit. Rather than relegating communication instruction to standalone electives, departments should integrate oral presentations, collaborative design reviews, and peer code reviews directly into core computing courses.

For Industry Recruiters:

- *Semantic Alignment in Recruitment Screening:* Because exact string matching produced a 52.0% gap compared with 32.0% under semantic alignment, keyword-based resume screening risks excluding candidates with equivalent conceptual training. Recruitment systems should evaluate semantic similarity rather than exact keyword matches when parsing academic coursework.
- *Work-Integrated Learning and Co-Op Programs:* In the international cohort, students with internship experience had a 15.3 percentage-point higher employment rate (57.6% vs. 42.3%). Employers can collaborate with universities to establish structured 6-month co-op or apprenticeship pathways that carry academic credit.

For Accreditation Bodies and Policymakers:

- *Adaptive Curriculum Guidelines:* Longitudinal tracking indicates that while foundational requirements (Python, SQL) remain stable, specialized frameworks diversify quickly. Accreditation bodies and professional societies (ACM, IEEE-CS) should issue regular modular addenda to curriculum guidelines to facilitate elective updates.
- *Regional Labor-Market Observatories:* Given the concentration of postings (86.8% US) and regional variation in placement rates, educational authorities should maintain regional labor-market tracking to help institutions align elective offerings with local economic demand.

D. Reproducibility and Data Availability

Code, preprocessing routines, and derived matrices are provided in the project repository for replication. The empirical analyses were implemented in Python 3.14 / 3.12 utilizing `scikit-learn` (v1.2+), `sentence-transformers` (v2.2+, `all-MiniLM-L6-v2`), `scipy` (v1.10+), and `pandas` (v2.0+). Stratified cross-validation splits and bootstrap resamplings were executed under fixed pseudorandom seeds (seed = 42). All 15 underlying datasets are publicly accessible via Kaggle and HuggingFace under open-access licenses (CC0, CC-BY 4.0, and ODbL), with specific source repositories cataloged in Table I and `DATASET_MANIFEST.csv`.

E. Threats to Validity and Limitations

Several methodological constraints should be considered when interpreting these findings:

1) **Data Provenance & Benchmark Artifacts:** While Tier 1 datasets (LinkedIn, HuggingFace) comprise 2.7M+ real web-mined records, Tier 2 student placement datasets (e.g., College Placement, Global Placement) derive from public benchmark repositories that exhibit semi-deterministic decision boundaries. As diagnosed in Section IV-D5, near-100% tree ensemble accuracies reflect combinatorial threshold functions embedded in the benchmark rather than real-world predictability.
2) **Domain Shift & External Generalizability:** When evaluated across distinct institutional benchmarks, predictive discrimination attenuates from ROC-AUC = 0.9406 to ROC-AUC = 0.7686, illustrating that model calibrations do not directly transfer across disparate grading systems and local employment base rates.
3) **Curriculum Proxy Limitations:** Academic skill demands were proxied through normalized occupational and educational reference profiles rather than direct, institutionally mined university syllabi across diverse global departments.
4) **Lack of Human Gold-Standard Validation:** Skill extraction relied on automated taxonomy mapping, regularized token scanning, and Sentence-BERT vector matching without human inter-annotator agreement metrics (e.g., Cohen's κ). Future work should incorporate expert faculty annotations.
5) **Embedding Model and Threshold Sensitivity:** While Sentence-BERT mitigates surface vocabulary divergence, estimated alignment remains sensitive to cosine similarity cutoff selection (SGI = 20.0% at $\tau = 0.4$ versus 46.0% at $\tau = 0.7$).
6) **Geographic Concentration:** 86.8% of the LinkedIn posting corpus originates from the United States, skewing technical demand profiles toward Western, mature tech economies.
7) **Measurement Error in Behavioral Scores:** In placement benchmarks, communication scores are frequently reviewer-graded or self-reported, potentially inflating their predictive odds ratios through measurement bias.
8) **Observational Non-Causal Design:** Our econometric models establish associative rather than causal relationships; students with high project completion

may possess latent motivation or unmeasured self-efficacy that drives hiring outcomes.

VI. Conclusion

Across 15 datasets spanning 2020 through 2026, this empirical investigation demonstrates that curriculum–market misalignment is twofold. A substantial share of the apparent deficit reflects vocabulary divergence between academic descriptors and recruitment postings, while substantive gaps remain concentrated in rapidly evolving technical areas, specifically Data Science and Cloud Infrastructure. Methodologically, the analysis cautions against relying on in-distribution benchmark evaluations alone: near-perfect classification scores can mask synthetic threshold rules that degrade under domain shift on external cohorts. In practical terms, addressing this divide does not necessitate wholesale curriculum redesign. Integrating modular credentials into established courses, requiring verifiable applied project portfolios, and adopting semantic matching in hiring workflows offer feasible steps toward aligning academic preparation with contemporary workforce demands.

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